University for the Creative Arts

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Dissertation Title: Social media sentiment analytics and its impact on consumer purchase intentions

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ABSTRACT

This research explores the influence of social media sentiment analysis on consumer purchase decisions, focusing on how online sentiment can shape consumer behaviour in their purchasing decisions. The research discusses the importance of sentiment analytics in today's marketing, sentiment and consumer behaviour, the effect of positive and negative sentiments, and how sentiment analytics can help in organisational decision-making. The method of the research is quantitative by means of a structured questionnaire, and the 50 respondents include active social media users obtained by convenience sampling technique. Survey techniques, such as frequencies, percentages, bar charts and pie charts, are used to analyse primary data and look for patterns in consumer responses. The results show that social media, online reviews, influencer recommendations and user-generated content are all significant factors for consumers when deciding what to buy. Negative sentiment has a greater impact on purchase avoidance than positive sentiment has on purchase intention, and trust and content credibility had a significant impact on consumer evaluations. The research also shows the value of sentiment analytics for organisations to track consumer sentiment, boost client interactions, and optimise marketing campaigns. The study concludes that the use of sentiment analysis in social media is a strategic tool to optimize customer related marketing and improve the competitiveness of the organisation.

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DISSERTATION THESIS



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INTRODUCTION

Research background

Social media platforms have been growing at an unprecedented speed, changing the way consumers relate to brands, products, and services. Within the last ten years, Instagram, Facebook, X (formerly Twitter), TikTok, and YouTube have gone from communication and entertainment functions to becoming digital marketplaces where customers proactively share experiences, advice, and opinions. Unlike the conventional marketing channels, social media provides a platform for two-way communication, allowing consumers to be part of conversations about brands. Consumers share a tremendous amount of information through reviews, comments on products, sharing of experiences, experiences in video format, liking, and participation in discussions that influence other people's perceptions and purchasing decisions. As a result, businesses can no longer solely rely on traditional market research techniques but are increasingly turning to social media data to gain insights into customer attitudes and market dynamics (Rahardjo et al., 2024).

The rise of user-generated content (UGC) is a massive change in the way that consumers make decisions. Many consumers will read reviews on the Internet, influencers' recommendations, customer feedback, discussion forums and comments on social media to assess the quality, reliability and value of the products and services they are considering buying. A positive discussion on the web can build consumer trust, improve brand reputation, and boost purchase intention, while a negative discussion or viral complaint can have a bad impact on a company's image and consumer confidence in the blink of an eye. When information travels through social media at a very fast pace, the opinions of consumers can reach thousands or even millions of potential customers in a very short time. Such dependence on online opinions has spurred organisations to keep tracking and analysing digital conversations regularly so that they can proactively address the concerns of their customers, as well as potential market opportunities (Duan, 2025).

With the proliferation of such digital interactions, social media sentiment analysis has become a useful tool for businesses looking to better comprehend customers' sentiment. Social media

sentiment analysis is the systematic gathering, understanding and analysis of opinions, sentiments, emotions, and behavioural intentions of social media users on these platforms. Uses state-of-the-art technologies like artificial intelligence (AI), machine learning (ML), natural language processing (NLP), and text mining to automatically sort online content into positive, negative, or neutral sentiment categories. More advanced sentiment analysis solutions can also be used to detect emotional responses like happiness, frustration, anger, satisfaction, excitement, or disappointment, offering more in-depth insights into the customer's experience beyond what survey tools can provide. The use of these technologies allows organisations to analyse millions of social media posts in real time, making sentiment analytics a valuable tool for tracking consumer sentiment at scale (Rahardjo et al., 2024).

Machine learning and AI algorithms have made a huge leap in sentiment analysis accuracy and efficiency by detecting language patterns, context, and shifting consumer language. Meanwhile, NLP allows computer systems to interpret human language, which also incorporates slang, abbreviations, emojis, hashtags and other informal expressions that are used across various social media channels. With the progression of AI advances, sentiment analysis can now communicate more nuanced feelings, sarcasm, and context, which were once hard to decipher correctly. The practical use of sentiment analytics has grown in many industries such as retail, healthcare, hospitality, financial services, telecom and e-commerce, where building a customer sentiment profile is critical to being competitive (Duan, 2025).

Research Aim and Objective

Research Aim

The objective of the research is to investigate how social media sentiment analytics influence consumer purchasing intentions. The study aims to comprehend the effect of positive, negative and neutral sentiments posted on social media platforms on the decision-making and purchasing behaviour of consumers.

Research Objectives

1. To examine the concept and significance of social media sentiment analytics in modern marketing.
2. To investigate the relationship between social media sentiment and consumer purchase intentions.
3. To evaluate the influence of positive and negative social media sentiments on consumers' purchasing decisions.
4. To assess the role of sentiment analytics in helping organisations understand consumer behaviour.
5. To provide recommendations for businesses on the effective use of social media sentiment analytics to improve marketing strategies and customer engagement.

Research Scope

The study aims to explore the effects of social media sentiment analysis on consumer purchasing decision-making among social media users. It analyses feelings as expressed in online reviews, comments, ratings, and discussions on widely used social networking sites like Facebook, Instagram, X (Twitter), TikTok and YouTube. The study is limited to consumers who are active in using social media as a tool to get information and make purchasing decisions for products. This research focuses on perceptions and behavioural intentions of the consumer and not the actual buying behaviour.

Research Methodology

The method of this study is quantitative research, which aims to explore the influence of social media sentiment analysis on consumer purchasing. A quantitative methodology is appropriate as this allows for numerical data to be collected, which can then be analysed statistically to look for patterns, relationships and trends between the variables of the study. It is an objective and systematic way to measure the perceptions of respondents' social media sentiment and analyse how that sentiment affects their intention to purchase. In addition, quantitative research enables

the examination of relationships between variables and increases the reliability and generalisability of the results with standardised methods of data collection.

Primary data will be gathered through the use of a structured questionnaire to help capture the views of respondents about social media sentiment analytics and its effects on purchasing behaviour. The study will be conducted on 50 active users of social media and will employ the convenience sampling method of selecting the respondents. This is a non-probability sampling method because it enables the researcher to reach the people who are easy to access and actively using the social media platforms in order to be able to gain information within the limited time and resources available.

Research Structure

The research is organised into four main chapters, each designed to address a specific aspect of the study and to ensure a logical progression from the theoretical background to the research findings and conclusions.

Chapter One presents the introductory literature review, providing an overview of the key concepts related to social media sentiment analytics, consumer purchasing intentions, and the relationship between these two variables. The chapter reviews existing academic literature to establish the research context, explains the growing importance of sentiment analysis in digital marketing, and identifies gaps in the current body of knowledge that justify the need for the present study.

Chapter Two provides a more comprehensive literature review, critically examining previous studies on the influence of social media sentiment on consumer behaviour. The chapter discusses the impact of positive and negative sentiment, the role of artificial intelligence (AI), machine learning (ML), and natural language processing (NLP) in sentiment analytics, the influence of user-generated content, online reviews, electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM), influencer marketing, and consumer trust. It also presents the theoretical framework underpinning the study and develops the research hypotheses based on the reviewed literature.

Chapter Three outlines the research methodology adopted for the study. It describes the quantitative research approach, research design, sampling strategy, data collection procedures,

questionnaire development, measurement scales, ethical considerations, and data analysis techniques used to examine the relationship between social media sentiment analytics and consumer purchasing intentions.

Chapter Four presents the data analysis, findings, discussion, and conclusion. The collected data are analysed using appropriate statistical methods, and the results are interpreted in relation to the research objectives and existing literature. The chapter concludes by summarising the key findings, discussing their theoretical and practical implications, acknowledging the study's limitations, and providing recommendations for future research and managerial practice.

CHAPTER ONE – LITERATURE REVIEW I

1.1 Introduction to the Chapter

The fast growth of digital technologies of communication in the last 10 years has radically altered the dependence between consumers and brands. Social media platforms are no longer mere networking platforms but multifaceted digital ecosystems where consumers have come to influence brand narratives by continuously creating and pushing opinion-based content. The deciphering of the emotional cues within this enormous body of user-generated information has become a strategic necessity to both marketing scholars and practitioners.

Social media sentiment analytics, which is the systematic computational inference and decoding of consumer attitudes, emotions and opinions based on the analysis of social media data is one of the most important methodological improvements in the field of contemporary marketing intelligence. This chapter is a critical review of the scholarly research on the term and importance of social media sentiment analytics in the framework of modern-day marketing practice based on peer-reviewed publications published in 2022-2025. It follows the technological and conceptual evolution of the field, places it in the context of the existing theories of consumer behaviour and information processing, and describes the major theoretical gaps that explain the empirical research project that is conducted in the current study.

1.2 The Evolution of Social Media as a Marketing Channel

1.2.1 From Broadcast to Participatory Communication

The replacement of the one-way mass media by the interactive and participatory social media platforms is a structural change in the nature of marketing communication. As Kaplan and Haenlein (2023) note, social media develops networked spaces with high levels of user engagement, openness, and dialogue, which radically changes the balance of power between the brands and their fans. The pre-social media days saw the brands owning the major mediums, which transmitted information regarding their products and services to the consumers; today, the informational monopoly of the marketers has been shattered by the spread of consumer-created

content that is more trusted, distributed and emotionally legitimate than the message that was controlled by the marketer.

The platforms like Facebook, Instagram, Tik Tok, YouTube, and X (where Twitter used to be) have developed a space where the opinion of the consumer is not only captured but also enhanced by sharing, commenting, and algorithmic recommendation, making online sentiment management one of the major concerns of brand managers (Hussain, Song and Niu, 2022). This change has far-reaching implications on marketing strategy. Companies that used to build brand perception using a programme of controlled advertising messages are now forced to deal with an unending, real-time flow of consumer-created content that not only mirrors but shapes the attitudes of the people towards their companies.

1.2.2 The Rise of User-Generated Content and Electronic Word-of-Mouth

The development of user-generated content (UGC) and electronic word-of-mouth (eWOM) are central to the revolution of social media into a strategically important marketing space. UGC is seen by the consumer as more authentic, more credible and a more accurate reflector of the real product experience than marketer-produced content, and is therefore a strong predictor of purchase intention and brand consideration. Hussain, Song and Niu (2022) establish the most important reasons behind eWOM sharing in social media such as altruism, identity expression, enjoyment of the platform, and economic benefits and prove that the amount and quality of eWOM are strong predictors of downstream consumer behaviour. The magnitude of eWOM production implies that social media have created a constantly updated and globally spread database of consumer experience that is, theoretically, available to any organisation with the analytical capacity to work with it.

The applied problem is just in that very analytical ability. The amount, speed, and types of social media data (text, pictures, video, emojis, hashtags, audio, etc) significantly outweigh the processing capabilities of human analysts and, therefore, automated computational methods are not only convenient but also necessary. The magnitude of this problem is exemplified in the analysis of social media discourse in response to the COVID-19 pandemic, as Jiang et al. (2022) show that only a complex machine learning and topic modelling can help extract meaningful

insights out of this data. Their contribution is representative of the greater methodological urge behind the creation of social media sentiment analytics as a field.

1.3 Conceptual Foundations of Social Media Sentiment Analytics

1.3.1 Defining Sentiment Analysis: Scope and Dimensions

The most detailed and commonly referred to taxonomic structure of sentiment analysis as offered by Liu (2022) identifies three major levels of analytical granularity. Document-level analysis gives a single sentiment polarity to a whole text of text - e.g., a product review or a post on social media - as positive, negative or neutral. Sentence-level analysis breaks this assessment down to the sentence-by-sentence level, which allows a more detailed view of what exactly in a consumer experience elicits a positive or negative reaction. The most granular level of analysis and the most valuable in terms of analysis used to market a product or service, aspect-level analysis can determine what attributes of a product or service consumers are expressing sentiment about and allow organisations to know what features are leading to consumer satisfaction or dissatisfaction. This multi-level perspective is critical to marketing practitioners who want to achieve an actionable insight of sentiment data instead of tracking an aggregate brand sentiment.

In addition to classification of polarity, sophisticated sentiment analysis engines can also identify individual emotional states such as joy, anger, frustration, surprise and anticipation which can give a more detailed and in-depth view of consumer experience than positive/negative classification. Cambria et al. (2022) capture the evolution of affective computing solutions that integrate sentiment analysis with emotion recognition to allow organisations to learn not only how consumers feel positively or negatively about a brand but also what exact emotional reactions their products and messages are inducing.

1.3.2 From Lexicons to Deep Learning: The Technological Trajectory

The history of methodological sentiment analysis is marked by a shift towards lexicon-based rule-based sentiment analysis and data-driven machine learning and deep learning systems. Early sentiment analysis systems were based on manually maintained dictionaries like LIWC, AFINN, and SentiWordNet, which assigned a positive or negative valence to individual words, and which summed the scores of those words to obtain a sentiment rating of a piece of text. Although

transparent and interpretable, these lexicon-based methods have serious drawbacks in the case of social media language, which is defined by irony, sarcasm, vocabulary specific to a domain and context-related meaning that cannot be measured merely by word-level scoring. Dhaoui, Webster and Tan (2023) directly compare the results of lexicon-based and machine learning methods in a marketing setting and decisively find that machine learning methods are much more effective in classification accuracy, especially in the case of the informal, context-dependent language common to social media posts.

The emergence of deep learning systems, especially recurrent neural networks (RNNs), convolutional neural networks (CNNs), and, more recently, transformer-based systems such as BERT and GPT has raised the performance bar of sentiment analysis significantly. In a systematic review of deep learning methods to sentiment analysis, Zhang, Wang and Liu (2022) outline how the accuracy, speed, and sensitivity to context of neural network designs have improved over the generations. Transformer-based models are especially important since their attention mechanisms allow them to learn long-range contextual dependencies in text, and thus they can properly learn the sentiment in context-dependent sentences where meaning is not dictated by the valence of individual words.

The latest point in this trend, the use of large generative AI models to sentiment analysis, is reported by Duan (2025), who shows that generative AI can not only categorize the existing sentiment but can also predict how consumer sentiment towards a brand or a product is likely to change, which qualifies as a qualitative improvement in the strategic applicability of sentiment analytics to the process of marketing decision-making. These technological advances have significant practical ramifications on the marketing practitioners. A systematic review of NLP use in marketing analytics by Gupta and Singhvi (2023) reveals that organisations using advanced NLP-based sentiment analytics achieve high rates of reported improvements in consumer insight generation accuracy, brand health monitoring speed, and effectiveness of targeted marketing communications.

1.4 The Strategic Significance of Sentiment Analytics in Modern Marketing

1.4.1 Real-Time Brand Health Monitoring

Real time brand health monitoring is one of the most strategically valuable uses of social media sentiment analytics in the contemporary marketing. Historical methods of brand health measurement such as reliance on periodic surveys, focus groups and brand tracking studies, offer retrospective views of consumer attitudes that are necessarily constrained in time resolution and sensitivity to dynamic market situations. Sentiment analytics, in contrast, provides a real time, high frequency signal of consumer attitudes which updates over time as social media conversation changes. Chowdhury (2024) reviews the use of sentiment analytics in brand management in various industry segments and reports an impressive increase in speed and accuracy of brand health monitoring, realised by organisations that have introduced real-time sentiment analytics functionality.

Most importantly, the author shows that the lead time benefit that sentiment analytics offers, i.e. the difference between when a negative sentiment trend starts and when the organisation realises it, is a key factor of how effective the brand management response is. This real-time feature came in especially handy at the time of the COVID-19 pandemic, when changes in consumer attitudes, priorities, and behaviours were changing at an exceptionally high and unpredictable rate. Pantano et al. (2023) study the role of retailers who applied sentiment analytics in navigating the upheaval brought about by the pandemic, and discover that organisations that had well-developed sentiment monitoring systems were far more likely to modify their marketing messages, pricing, and product offerings to capture the new consumer sentiment. Their results give strong empirical support of the strategic importance of sentiment analytics in contexts typified by high volatility and uncertainty - exactly those contexts that are becoming more and more typical of modern consumer markets.

Real-time sentiment monitoring has a value that goes beyond brand health to include category level intelligence. By monitoring sentiment on their brands and the market as a whole, when organisations monitor sentiment not on a brand-by-brand basis but on the basis of an entire product category and a segment of the market, they can detect macro-level changes in consumer attitudes that can potentially indicate a threat or an opportunity.

1.4.2 Competitive Intelligence and Market Positioning

In addition to brand health monitoring, social media sentiment analytics offers organisations a competitive intelligence powerhouse as it allows organisations to monitor consumer attitudes towards competitor brands and products in real-time. Traditional competitive intelligence methods, based on published reports, financial disclosures and periodic market research, are intermittent, backward, and not adequately sensitive to the subtle and constantly changing world of consumer attitudes. Sentiment analytics, in comparison, gives a real-time, granular and dynamically updated view of how consumers rate rival brands against their own. Gao et al. (2022) illustrate the use of a computational text analysis of online review data to show how organisations can recognise competitive threats and opportunities by mapping the sentiment space surrounding competitor brands, understanding the exact product attributes and service dimensions in which rivals are viewed favourably or unfavourably by the consumer.

This competitive intelligence solution allows marketing strategists to discover differentiation opportunities as well as to create positioning strategies that capitalize on weaknesses that have been detected in competitor sentiment profile. Sentiment analytics also has a competitive intelligence value as seen in its use in new product development and management of innovation pipeline. Through systematic search in social media discourse of unmet consumer needs, quality complaints and new category trends, organisations can formulate product innovation strategies that are closely aligned with new consumer preferences. Arora and Predmore (2023) show in a longitudinal investigation of brand equity dynamics that organisations that systematically incorporate sentiment analytics within competitive intelligence processes attain much greater brand equity scores over time than do organisations that use traditional, periodic research methods. Cumulative competitive advantage created by the long-term investment in sentiment analytics capability, they believe, is one of the greatest and least recognized sources of sustainable differentiation in modern marketing.

1.5 Theoretical Frameworks Underpinning Sentiment Influence on Consumers

1.5.1 The Elaboration Likelihood Model

The most common theoretical framework used in the cognition of the social media sentiment and its effects on consumer attitudes and behaviour is the Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM) by

Petty and Cacioppo. The ELM suggests that persuasive messages are handled by two routes: the central route which involves attentive, careful consideration of the quality of arguments and evidence; or the peripheral route which involves the use of heuristic cues - such as source credibility, message popularity, emotional tone - that allow quick formation of attitude without extensive cognitive processing. Bhattacherjee and Sanford (2023) use the ELM framework in the example of social media influence, showing that social media sentiment is more of a peripheral processing cue, allowing consumers to make quick attitude judgements based on the emotional valence of the social media content without the cognitive effort involved in central route processing. The implications of this insight to marketing strategy are significant: the exposure of consumers to large amounts of positively valenced social media messages about a brand leads to a strong peripheral cue which facilitates the formation of positive attitudes and purchase intention in the absence of detailed product consideration.

1.5.2 Social Proof Theory and Influencer-Mediated Sentiment

The Cialdini work on influence theory forms the basis of the social proof which forms a complementary explanation of the influence of social media sentiment on consumer behaviour. The social proof principle is that people rely on the attitudes and behaviours of other people to inform their own decisions especially in uncertain circumstances. The aggregate social sentiment that other consumers show towards a brand or product, in the social context of social media, can be viewed as a type of social proof that confirms or dissuades the purchase intention. Lim et al. (2022) discuss the effect of influencer-created sentiment on consumer purchase intention, in which influencer endorsements in the context of parasocial relationships that consumers form with influencers gives their view a credibility and authenticity that generic UGC may not always accomplish. This intermediating nature of consumer attitude in this relationship highlights the significance of sentiment analytics systems that are able to differentiate between various sources of social media content and assign weight to the sentiment signals.

Further empirical supports of the social proof mechanism as applied to influencer marketing are found in the work of Adaba (2025), who show that influencer endorsements have a strong and direct influence on consumer decision-making and purchase intentions, with the sentiment valence of the endorsement, specifically whether the influencer is explicitly enthusiastic or cautiously positive or implicitly lukewarm, being a major factor of the persuasive effect. These

results imply that successful sentiment analytics programmes should include both organic consumer conversation and the regulated influencer marketing ecosystem, tracking the sentiment of influencer content and the comment communities around it as its independent and strategically significant data streams. Social media sentiment and influencer marketing relationship has also been enlightened by the work on the parasocial dynamics that make influencer-generated sentiment especially compelling.

Tafesse and Wood (2023) show that patterns of long-term engagement between influencers and their followers result in sentiment environments that are characterised by high levels of trust and social identification and cause sentiment conveyed in these communities to have disproportionate power on purchase intention compared to the same amount of sentiment conveyed in anonymous consumer forums. The authors contend that the brands that tactically interact with the communities of influencers as distinct sentiment systems, as opposed to merely using influencer content as advertising placements, are more likely to produce enduring positive sentiment impacts that will last beyond the short-term campaign timeframes and have an enduring impact on purchase decisions over longer time spans. This observation supports the need to create sentiment analytics tools that could differentiate among the various forms of social media community and weight their sentiment indicators.

1.6 Limitations and Gaps in the Existing Literature

Although the amount and complexity of existing research regarding social media sentiment analytics are significant, the present study has some important gaps that support the need to conduct the empirical research. First, the literature available is often dedicated to single platforms, especially Twitter and Amazon reviews, which restrict the ability to generalise the results to the more holistic and more inclusive context of social media consumers use nowadays. Cross-platform sentiment dynamics, such as how the same consumer can have varied sentiments towards a brand on different platforms as a reaction to platform norms, audience makeup, and content format, are not well comprehended (Fan and Gordon, 2023).

Second, although the general connection between social media sentiment and purchase intention is already known, the mechanism that this connection occurs, such as the mediation of trust, social identity, and information processing mode has not been thoroughly charted between

various product categories and consumer groups. Third, the majority of the quantitative research that exists is based on the secondary analysis of publicly available social media data, which does not answer questions regarding the congruency between the stated online sentiment and actual purchasing behaviour. The current research fills these gaps, surveying active users of social media directly on their experience of social media sentiment and its role in their purchase decisions, gathering primary data on a relationship that has thus far been mainly discussed using secondary data.

1.7 Chapter Summary

The chapter has provided the conceptual and theoretical background of the current research through a critical review of the scholarly literature on the concept, development, and strategic importance of social media sentiment analytics in contemporary marketing. The review has followed how social media has evolved into a communication medium into a strategically important marketing space, which is typified by large amounts of user generated content that is emotionally expressive. It has reported the history of technological improvements, starting with lexicon-based systems, then machine learning, and finally generative AI, that have enabled and made practically useful real-time, large-scale sentiment analysis. It has placed sentiment analytics in clear theoretical frameworks, specifically the Elaboration Likelihood Model and Social Proof Theory, which elucidate the processes by which sentiment affects consumer attitudes and behaviour. And it has found critical gaps in the literature that the empirical aspect of the study is intended to fill. In the next chapter, they are further developed with a critical look at the empirical evidence on the relationship between social media sentiment and consumer purchasing decision, the dissimilar influence of positive and negative sentiment, application of analytics to consumer cognition, and marketing strategy implications.

CHAPTER TWO – LITERATURE REVIEW II

2.1 Introduction to the Chapter

The initial literature review chapter defined the conceptual and theoretical framework of the social media sentiment analytics and its increasing importance in contemporary marketing. The second chapter of the review, in its turn, proceeds with the review by critically reviewing the empirical literature directly related to the four specific research objectives of the study. Based on peer-reviewed studies published in 2022-25 and found in Google Scholar, the chapter will discuss: how social media sentiment is related to consumer purchase intentions; how positive and negative sentiment differentially affect purchasing decisions; how sentiment analytics can be used to gain better insight into consumer behaviour; and how sentiment analytics can be applied to marketing strategy and customer engagement. Each section summarizes results of a number of empirical studies, finds out the points of agreement and disagreement and extracts the practical implications of marketing management. The chapter ends with the description of the theoretical framework and research hypotheses which will be used in the quantitative study that is described in the following chapters.

2.2 Social Media Sentiment and Consumer Purchase Intentions

2.2.1 The Empirical Evidence Base

The hypothesis that the sentiment of social media has a strong and quantifiable effect on consumer purchasing intentions has established a large and growing body of empirical evidence. Rahardjo, Andriana and Prasastono (2024) implement a machine learning-based sentiment classification model to analyse the social media data and test the relationship between this sentiment and purchase intention scores measured in consumer surveys and establish a strong positive correlation between positive social media sentiment and expressed purchase intention in various product categories. More importantly, the authors show that this relationship is not a result of already existing positive brand attitudes - consumers who indicate consumption of predominantly positive social media content about a brand that they had not previously considered show significantly higher purchase intentions, and this effect shows evidence of a causal sentiment-to-intention relationship and not just a correlation between attitude and

purchase behaviour. Chen (2025) presents converging evidence, using a methodologically innovative hybrid of structural equation modelling and machine learning to uncover the direct and indirect influence of social media sentiment on purchase intention.

This research, based on a massive cross-platform sample of social media posts and matched consumer survey data, shows that the social media sentiment is the single most powerful predictor of purchase intention in the model, and it has a higher share of explained variance than product quality perceptions, price sensitivity, or brand familiarity. The consistency of this result within a methodologically sound design provides a lot of credence to the theoretical assumption that social media sentiment is not just a marginal factor affecting buying intention but a focal determinant in consumer decision making in the online market. Ismael (2025) continues this discussion to the particular group of young consumers, a cohort that is of particular strategic value due to both its current purchasing power and its disproportionate impact on the overall social media sentimental trends.

2.2.2 The Mediating Role of Trust and eWOM Credibility

Although the sentiment-intention relationship is well known, there has been an increasing number of studies on the processes of how sentiment has its effects, consumer trust and eWOM credibility are becoming some of the most crucial mediating constructs. When consumers are subjected to mostly positive attitude regarding a brand on social media this creates trust in the brand as it is a distributed signal of brand quality and brand reliability by a source who is perceived to be more credible and uninterested than marketer-mediated messages. The structural equation modelling presented by Mehta and Bhatt (2024) illustrates that in e-commerce, consumer trust completely mediates the connection between experienced social media sentiment and purchase intention, indicating that the mechanism by which sentiment affects purchase decisions is inherently a trust-building process, as opposed to a direct attitudinal change.

The implications of this finding to marketing practice are significant: to use positive social media sentiment to generate purchase intention organisations must develop and strengthen consumer trust by adopting strategies that develop and support consumer trust, such as open communication with customers, authentic brand communication, and proactive management of negative sentiment events that may undermine the consumer trust upon which purchase intention

is based. Credibility of eWOM, which in itself is a major source of the sentiment expression and transmission through social media, has been singled out as a major moderator of the sentiment-intention relationship. Not every social media sentiment has the same persuasive power: sentiment expressed by perceived experts, by consumers with large and active followings, or by those with proven product expertise should have more persuasive power than otherwise anonymous or low credibility sources.

2.3 The Influence of Positive and Negative Sentiment on Purchasing Decisions

2.3.1 Asymmetric Effects and the Negativity Bias

The first of the most coherent and practically implicative findings in the literature of social media sentiment regards the asymmetry of the impact of positive and negative sentiment on consumer purchasing behaviour. Basing its arguments on the wider psychological research on loss aversion and the negativity bias, or the documented tendency of negative stimuli to have more cognitive and affective influence than an equivalent volume of positive stimuli, studies have consistently shown that a negative social media attitude most strongly depresses purchase intention, with a positive attitude of the same magnitude having a stronger positive effect on purchase intention. Stieglitz and Dang-Xuan (2022) give a critical mechanism to comprehend this distributional level asymmetry, showing that negatively valent content on social media has much higher sharing rates than positively valent content. This difference in virality implies that negative sentiment goes viral faster than positive sentiment of equal intensity, and amplifies the negativity bias at the individual level with a distributional amplification effect on the market level.

This asymmetry has important practical consequences to the marketing management. Arora and Predmore (2023), based on a longitudinal study of brand equity, prove that a single high-profile adverse event, e.g., a viral customer complaint, product failure, or a brand controversy, can undo the brand equity gains gained over months of consistently positive social media sentiment. They propose that, as a risk management consideration, preventing and quickly containing negative sentiment events should be given greater priority in sentiment analytics programmes than the creation of positive sentiment, based on a downside risk of negative sentiment being greater than the upside potential of equivalent positive sentiment. This observation proposes an unequal

assignment of analytical and managerial resources in sentiment monitoring programmes, where more attention should be directed to identify and prompt action on negative sentiment (emerging negative sentiment) rather than focus on enhancement of positive sentiment.

2.3.2 The Positive Sentiment Advantage: Scale, Authenticity, and Sustained Effect

Although negative sentiment management is the most crucial risk approach, the management of long-term positive sentiment is an effective source of competitive advantage. The compounding effect of a steady stream of positive social media sentiment generated naturally by contented customers and authentically authorized by influencers generates long-lasting positive correlations with a brand which substantially and consistently enhance purchase intention in consumer groups. He, Zha and Li (2024) show in their case study of the restaurant sector that the most effective forecasts of consumer traffic and revenue are the volume and consistency of positive social media sentiment and can be explained by mechanisms of social proof, aspirational identification, and reduced purchase risk perception.

More importantly, their longitudinal analysis demonstrates that the impact of continued positive sentiment accumulation can be obtained over time in a fashion that cannot be immediately countered by competitors, indicating that investment in positive sentiment generation can generate a long-term competitive advantage that is hard to counter with either high product quality or more aggressive advertising campaigns. Authenticity of positive sentiment has been found to be a moderating variable that is critical to the persuasive effect of positive sentiment. Consumers are becoming more aware when it comes to differentiating between organic, positively expressed positive sentiment that is genuinely expressed, and those that are manufactured or incentivised. Lim et al. (2022) show that the perceived authenticity of the influencer-brand relationship moderately affects the persuasive effect of the positive sentiment created by the influencer, with authentic, long-term brand advocates producing significantly greater purchase intention effects than influencers who are seen to be serving more as commercial pay-off. These results underscore the significance of authenticity as a quality measure of positive sentiment that advanced sentiment analytics programmes ought to attempt to measure as opposed to all positive sentiment being as persuasive.

2.4 Sentiment Analytics and Organisational Understanding of Consumer Behaviour

2.4.1 Consumer Segmentation and Behavioural Profiling

Social media sentiment analytics provides organisations with unprecedented consumer segmentation and behavioural profiling, and supplements (and in some aspects exceeds) the capabilities of traditional survey-based and transaction-based methodologies. Through sentiment patterns among demographic segments, geographical segments, products and social media, organisations can gain deep-granular insights into how consumer attitudes can differ among their customer segments and how such attitudinal variations can be converted into various behavioural propensities. The analysis of Twitter posts based on topic modelling shows that there are considerable and systematic differences in the pattern of sentiment expression within demographic groups, the most notable of which is based on gender, and it has important consequences on the segment-specific marketing strategy (Bao et al., 2023).

Their methodology shows how sophisticated text analytics can uncover insights of consumer segmentation that traditional survey methodologies, which are limited by their sampling designs and question types, often fail to do so. Sentiment analytics can be enhanced with other organisational data sources, which greatly increases the value of sentiment analytics to consumer understanding. When sentiment data is integrated with transactional records, CRM data, and demographic databases, organisations will be able to come up with predictive models which associate certain sentiment patterns to downstream behavioural performance such as the probability of making a purchase, the size of the basket, category switching and churn risk. In a large-scale empirical study, Kumar et al. (2024) find that sentiment dynamics which can be observed in the consumer-brand social media interactions are highly predictive of customer lifetime value, repurchase frequency and cross-category purchasing, indicating that sentiment analytics can act as an effective input to customer value management and personalisation strategies.

2.4.2 Trend Detection and Strategic Foresight

A growing significant use of sentiment analytics to the organisational consumer understanding is the use as a leading indicator of new consumer trends and market changes. The capability to monitor emergent attitudinal trends prior to their reflection in purchasing behaviour offers

organisations with an advantage of lead time in strategic planning, product development, and marketing investment decisions. Li and Wang (2023) show that NLP-based processing of social media sentiment data can detect new trends in consumer preference with a lead time of several weeks to months ahead of them showing in sales data, which is a true predictive tool that cannot be achieved by standard market research methods.

Their results demonstrate how sentiment analytics can be used as both diagnostic tool to comprehend the existing consumer attitudes and prognostic tool to predict the future developments of the market. Sentiment analytics is especially useful in trend-detection applications in fast-moving consumer categories where first-mover advantage is short-lived. Abdi and Williams (2022) point out that the dynamic and responsive intelligence capability which is offered by the continuous, longitudinal nature of social media sentiment data is fundamentally different in nature than the episodic snapshots offered by traditional market research. The authors propose sentiment analytics as a regular input to strategic planning as part of the environmental scanning and competitive analysis, and believe that those organisations that do not develop the capability will find themselves more and more in reactive modes to market changes that have been anticipated and prepared against by competitors who are increasingly analytically savvy.

2.4.3 Product Development and Customer Experience Intelligence

This sentiment analysis at an aspect level of the products and service experiences has provided a new source of customer intelligence in product development and customer experience management. Through a methodical extraction and aggregation of consumer ratings of individual product attributes, service dimensions and touchpoint experiences in the context of social media and online review data, organisations can determine the precise drivers of consumer satisfaction and dissatisfaction much more precisely and at significantly less expense than other traditional product testing and customer experience research methodologies. Cambria et al. (2022) report many industries using aspect-level sentiment analytics to product development decisions, and show how understanding of consumer-generated sentiment data has been used to inform product design, feature prioritisation, and quality improvement projects in a broad variety of industries. The practical usefulness of such applications is that they can give organisations a permanent and mass scale feedback of customer satisfaction on the quality of products and services offered by

organisations that is more representative, timely, and actionable than the periodic and often self-selected feedback that is offered by formal customer satisfaction surveys.

2.5 Sentiment Analytics in Marketing Strategy and Customer Engagement

2.5.1 Personalisation and Content Strategy

Sentiment analytics applied to the marketing strategy have produced considerable recorded results of enhancement to marketing efficiency, especially in the areas of personalisation and content strategy. Through sentiment profiling of individual consumers and consumer segments, organisations are able to tune their marketing communications to appeal to the particular attitudes, concerns and aspirations, which the sentiment data demonstrates. Fan and Gordon (2023) reveal that those organisations that use social media analytics to personalise the content receive dramatically better engagement rates, conversion rates, and customer satisfaction scores in comparison to those that use a segment-level or a product-level content strategy without considering individual sentiment indicators. The results are consistent with the rest of the literature on the effectiveness of personalisation, which has repeatedly shown that messages that are seen to be personally relevant and emotionally sensitive to the current attitudes that the recipient is facing are more convincing than generic messages sent to the mass market.

2.5.2 Customer Engagement and Community Management

The customer engagement strategy has been revolutionised by social media sentiment analytics which has allowed organisations to identify and prioritise engagement opportunities in real-time, which triggers a response to emerging consumer sentiment events before they snowball. Sentiment monitoring systems would help to respond to expressions of negative sentiment by alerting the community managers when they are detected, so that they can respond quickly and sensitively to the reaction of the affected consumers by clarifying their concerns, disproving misinformation, and showing that the brand is willing to satisfy its consumers. Tafesse and Wood (2023) show that the quality and responsiveness of brand interaction with consumer-generated content, which can be quantified by sentiment analytics, strongly predict follower interaction and, via this interaction, the spread of positive brand sentiment through social networks. They posit that community management, as directed by sentiment analytics, is not only a reactive

customer service operation but a proactive brand-building operation that determines the overall sentiment ecosystem within which purchase decisions are taken.

2.5.3 Crisis Management and Reputation Recovery

Probably the most dramatic instance of the strategic importance of sentiment analytics lies in crisis communication and reputation management. With the potential of negative sentiment to go viral on social networks in hours, the pace and efficiency of organisational response is a key determinant of reputational consequences. Organisational sentiment analytics can be used to identify the onset of crisis-level negative sentiment much earlier than organisations with traditional monitoring methods, and this gives the organisation a critical response window, which is always cited by the relevant literature as the key factor in crisis communication success. Pantano et al. (2023) present empirical evidence that retailers that had the best sentiment monitoring practices successfully navigated the reputation challenges of the COVID-19 pandemic more effectively than their less analytically sophisticated peers, in part because they were able to detect the emergent negative sentiment, including regarding product availability, safety measures, and pricing, promptly and respond with communications that alleviated consumer anxiety before escalating into crisis level.

2.6 Theoretical Framework

The current research paper is based on three complementary theoretical frameworks that, when combined, offer a detailed explanation of how social media sentiment can drive consumer buying intentions. The Elaboration Likelihood Model (ELM), which is elaborated in Chapter One, represents how social media sentiment is a peripheral processing cue that influences consumer attitude formation by low-effort heuristic processing, especially when consumers do not have the motivation or ability to evaluate a product in the central route. The Social Proof Theory describes the social-normative processes by which aggregate consumer sentiment, or the perceived attitudes of others, influences individual purchase decisions via conformity, validation, and less uncertainty. The Technology Acceptance Model (TAM) and subsequent ones offer a paradigm through which the perception of usefulness and ease of use of the sentiment analytics tools can be understood in terms of their acceptance and successful implementation by marketing organisations. These frameworks together produce a consistent body of testable predictions

regarding the connections between social media sentiment, consumer trust, purchase intention and marketing effectiveness that the quantitative study presented in the following chapters is intended to be empirically tested.

2.7 Research Hypotheses

H1: Consumer purchase intention is positively and significantly correlated with positive social media sentiment.

H2: The negative sentiment in social media is negatively and significantly related to consumer purchase intention.

H3: Consumer trust mediates the relationship between social media sentiment and consumer purchase intention.

H4: Sentiment analytics in social media is a key tool for improving organisational knowledge on consumer behaviour.

H5: The successful implementation of social media sentiment analytics has positive correlations with the effectiveness of marketing strategies and consumer engagement results.

2.8 Chapter Summary

The chapter has given a critique and an empirically based review of the literature on the four major research objectives of the study. The reviewed evidence confirms the theoretical claim that social media sentiment has a strong, multidimensional, and practically consequential impact on consumer purchasing intentions, and it works through the well-grounded theoretical mechanisms of trust formation, social proof, and peripheral information processing. The disproportionate effect of positive and negative sentiment on each other - concerning the negativity bias observed in the larger psychological literature - has significant strategic consequences for organisations operating their social media presence, as it suggests that special care is needed in the early detection and swift mitigation of instances of negative sentiment. Sentiment analytics has been identified as offering transformative consumer segmentation, trend discovery, and behavioural profiling capabilities to organisations that venture far beyond the ability of traditional market research methods to deliver consumer intelligence.

CHAPTER THREE – METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research philosophy

The philosophy of the research affects how assumptions are made when collecting, measuring and interpreting data for research. This study is based on the philosophy of observing, investigating and using measurable evidence objectively to examine the relationship between social media sentiment analytics and consumers' purchase intentions. It assumes that consumers' perceptions and behavioural intentions can be measured with structured data collection, and statistical analysis can be used to find patterns, relationships or trends (Yu and Zhu, 2024). This method aims to ensure an objective view of the results, based on facts and not on opinions or subjective interpretations.

The first objective of the research is to obtain facts from the respondents through the structured questionnaire, that measures variables among all the respondents. The use of standardisation of data collection methods ensures reliability, consistency and comparability of the results and reduces researcher bias. The statistical analysis of the impact of social media sentiment on the purchase intention and the magnitude and intensity of relationships among the study variables (Taherdoost, 2022). The study offers empirical results and conclusive evidence that can assist organisations to get a better understanding of consumer behaviour and learn some practical lessons on how sentiment analysis of social media can be used to improve a marketing strategy and engagement with the customer.

3.2 Research approach

The research method provides an organised approach to explore the relationship between social media sentiments and consumers' purchase intention. This is a logical study because it begins with a clear statement of the study objectives and measurable variables, so the study does not get lost and does not wander off during the conduct of the study. The method is based on the collection of quantitative data from the respondents using a structured questionnaire to obtain the social sentiment and the effect on the purchasing intentions of the respondents (Sapkota, 2024). The data gathered is organised, coded and subjected to analytic operations that would suggest relationships, variations, and important patterns between the variables used in the study.

The structured process helps the researcher assess if different types of social media sentiment have an impact on consumer decision-making and how much impact. It also promotes uniformity by asking the same questions and using the same measurement criteria for all participants so that the responses are more comparable. Data collection, variable measurement and the statistical evaluation are carefully planned and analysed, and the results are objective and based on observed evidence and not personal judgement. This approach guarantees that the outcomes are generated in a dependable and structured way that can effectively fulfil research aims (Adeyemi, 2024). The systematic study continues with a series of research activities, and the results are meaningful evidence that leads to insights regarding consumer purchase intentions and decision-making in marketing, considering social media sentiment analytics.

3.3 Research design

The research design offers a clear plan for conducting a study and ensures that the research aims are covered in an organised and systematic way. The design enables the data from a particular group of respondents to be gathered numerically and provides opportunities to examine relationships between the variables of the study. The basic research instrument is a structured questionnaire that allows the respondent to respond in a standardised manner that can be easily measured and analysed (Goodfellow, 2023). This research is based on a cross-sectional design in which the data is collected from the respondents at different times to reflect their sentiment towards social media and its influence on their buying intent at that time.

Closed-ended questions provide uniformity of answers and make statistical analysis easier. The research design also guides the selection of respondents that is undertaken during data collection, coding and analysing the data so that the data is consistent throughout the study. The ethical guidelines are followed in conducting the research, including voluntary participation, informed consent, confidentiality and anonymity, in order to ensure that the respondents are protected and the research is more valid (Oranga and Matere, 2025). The research design is appropriate for generating uniform empirical data and for understanding the relationship between social media sentiment analytics and consumers' purchase intentions.

3.4 Data collection

The study collects first-hand data from the respondents to get the first-hand experience of the sentiment analytics of social media and how it affects consumers' purchase intentions. In data collection, a structured questionnaire with closed-ended questions is used, that enables the respondents to respond and provide measurable and consistent answers. The items in the survey are related to social media usage, exposure to online reviews and opinions, perceptions of positive/negative sentiments, and purchase intention based on these sentiments (Doran et al., 2026). The statements are rated on a 5-point Likert scale, suitable for quantitative analysis, for most statements. The questionnaire is given to 50 respondents who are users of social media, obtained through convenience sampling.

The questionnaire is voluntarily completed by all the respondents after providing them with adequate information on the purpose of the study and the anonymity of the respondents. No personally identifiable data is collected, and the data is only used for academic research. Questionnaires were completed and checked for completeness and accuracy before coding and entering the responses into the statistical software for analysis (Kotronoulas, 2023). A structured data collection process results in uniformity in the data being collected for all participants and minimises the occurrence of differences in the data collected. This approach can deliver consistent numerical data that can be used to examine relationships between social media sentiment analytics and consumer purchase intent, and meet the aims of the study.

3.5 Data analysis

The information collected is then analysed using quantitative analysis, that can be used to investigate the participants' responses and identify any patterns in the attitudes toward social media and consumers' purchasing behaviour. Before the analysis, all the questionnaires were checked to determine whether they were complete or not. 50 of the active users of social media were the study's active subjects. The responses are coded and entered into a spreadsheet to ensure accurate organisation and processing of the data (Taherdoost, 2022). The analysis is mostly descriptive in nature, using frequencies and percentages to describe the respondents' characteristics and opinions about the study variables. Bar charts and pie charts with a pictorial representation of the distribution of responses make the findings easier to understand.

The graphical displays allow for comparisons to be made between each response category and identify important trends in consumer perceptions and purchase intentions. The discussions of the results of completed questionnaires follow the summary of statistics and visual tools to respond to each research objective. The analysis focuses on understanding the extent of the influence of positive, negative and neutral social media sentiment on consumers' intention to purchase (Yu and Zhu, 2024). The outcomes are analysed systematically in order to elucidate the patterns and implications for business. This type of analysis of data ensures the findings are presented in a structured, understandable and objective manner, that allows for valid findings from the responses gathered from the survey participants.

3.6 Sampling strategy

A convenience sampling technique is used to choose the subjects of the study since they are easily accessible and fulfil the requirements of the study. Given that it allows for convenient access to people who are active social media users and have experience with social media, online comments and reviews of products and services, this sampling type is suitable. The target sample comprises 50 respondents who are active on social media platforms and can give informed answers about the impact of social media sentiment on their purchase decisions. Convenience sampling applies to this study because it can be done at a convenient time for the study and requires fewer financial and administrative resources (Golzar et al., 2022). The findings do not represent the entire population because the sampling was non-probabilistic, but it can provide insight into consumer buying intentions when reflecting on the research questions and provide understanding of consumer sentiment within the context of social media sentiment analysis.

3.7 Validity and reliability

The validity and reliability are crucial to ensure the results of the research reflect the true relationship between social media sentiment analytics and consumer purchase intentions. The questionnaire is structured to obtain the research objectives and important variables of the research, thereby ensuring its validity. The questionnaire includes Precisely Defined and Easy-to-understand questions that gauge the social media sentiment and impact on the purchasing intent of the respondents. The language of the items minimises ambiguity and the chance of incorrect answers being given (Adeyemi, 2024). The same response format is

employed throughout the questionnaire to ensure uniformity in the way that the question is interpreted. Reliability may be achieved through the use of a structured questionnaire that is used to ask the same questions in the same sequence for all.

Standardised data collection methods minimise differences in administration and responses to the same questions. Closed-ended questions and a standard measurement scale also help to ensure consistency and reliability of the data collected by providing the person answering the question with a limited number of choices. Care is taken to carefully code the data so that the number of errors in recording the data is minimised and to ensure that the data remains accurate for analysis (Goodfellow, 2023). Responses are also checked for completeness before statistical analysis is carried out. These steps enhance the reliability of the study results and ensure that the data gathered is based on an equal foundation for studying the impact of social media sentiment analysis on consumer purchase decisions.

3.8 Research ethics

Throughout the study, ethics are adhered to ensure the rights, privacy and dignity of all participants are protected. The survey is non-obligatory, and the participants respond only if they have information on the aims of the research and what they are asked to do. All the subjects agree to participate in the study voluntarily, sign the informed consent, and agree to take the survey. The participants are also entitled to refuse to participate in the survey without providing a reason and without facing any consequences (Lindkvist et al., 2026). The study is respectful of confidentiality because no personally identifiable information is collected.

The answers are confidential and are for the purpose of educational research only. The data collected is stored securely, and only the researcher has access to the data to prevent unauthorised use or disclosure of the data. The results are reported in an anonymous manner. The researcher also ensures that the questions are respectful, unbiased and non-offensive to the participant and that they are not psychologically uncomfortable or upsetting (Kotronoulas, 2023). Research is undertaken with honesty, transparency and accuracy in data collection, analysis and reporting, and results are presented fairly, fully, without fabrication, manipulation and misrepresentation of data collected in the survey.

3.9 Research limitations

When interpreting the results of this study, it is important to consider the limitations of the research. The use of a quantitative survey to collect data means that there is no qualitative information to help understand why consumers feel the way they do about something. The small sample size (50 people) obtained through convenience sampling means that the findings of this research are less generalisable to all social media users than would be desired, and the findings are not representative of the total social media population as they focus only on people who actively use social media. The survey data relies entirely on self-reported information from respondents and may be distorted by the respondents' subjective opinions, willingness to provide accurate responses, or cognitive limitations of their memories (Oranga and Matere, 2025). Also, since the study was cross-sectional, the data were measured at a single point in time and do not capture changes in consumer attitudes or purchase intentions over time. Beyond these limitations, this research provides useful insight into the influence of social media sentiment analytics on consumer purchase intentions and can be used as support for future research as well as for practical marketing efforts.

CHAPTER FOUR – FINDINGS / ANALYSIS / DISCUSSION



4.1 Findings

1.

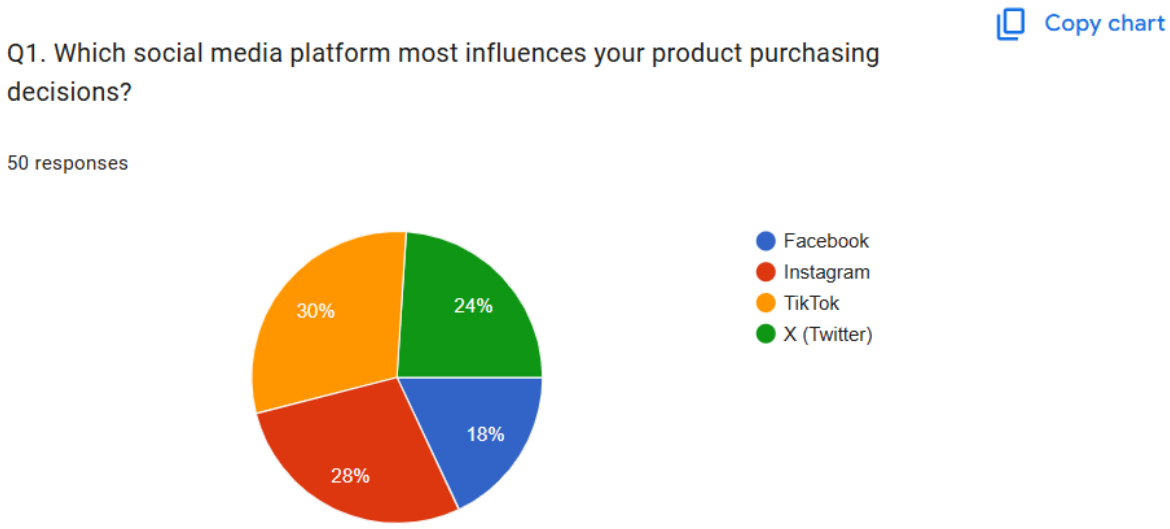


Figure: Preferred Social Media Platform Influencing Purchase Decisions

Source: (self-created)

According to the results, TikTok is the leading platform influencing consumers' purchasing process, with 30% of the answers, while Instagram is second with 28%. X (Twitter) comes in second with a 24% influence rate, and Facebook has the lowest rate at 18%. The results show engaging and interactive platforms have a greater impact on purchase intent than traditional social networking platforms. The features of consumers' preference for short videos, influencer videos, and user-generated recommendations make TikTok and Instagram very popular. They play a vital role in digital marketing efforts that seek to enhance customer interaction and impact purchasing decisions.

2.

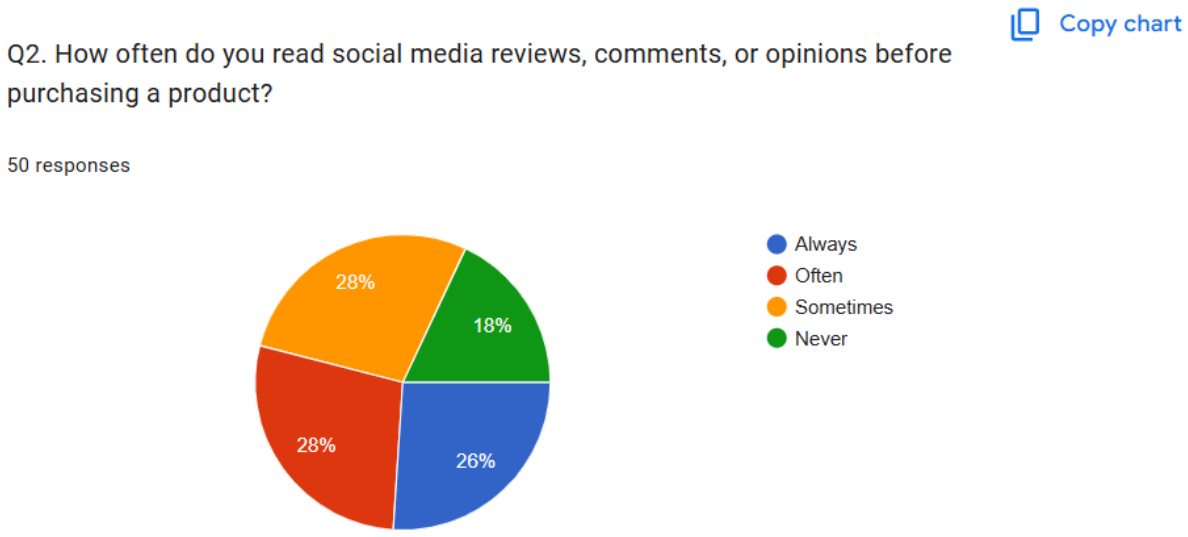


Figure: Frequency of Reading Social Media Reviews Before Purchasing

Source: (self-created)

The survey findings show that social media reviews, comments, and opinions are used by most of the respondents regularly for purchasing decisions. 26% of the respondents said they read online comments "always," 28 percent "often", and 28 percent "sometimes. 18% do not ever seek such opinions prior to buying products. The results suggest that social media has emerged as one of the crucial sources of information for the consumer decision-making process. This is a high proportion of people seeking advice online, or what is known as electronic word-of-mouth, that makes it clear why electronic WOM is a crucial element in the purchase decision.

3.

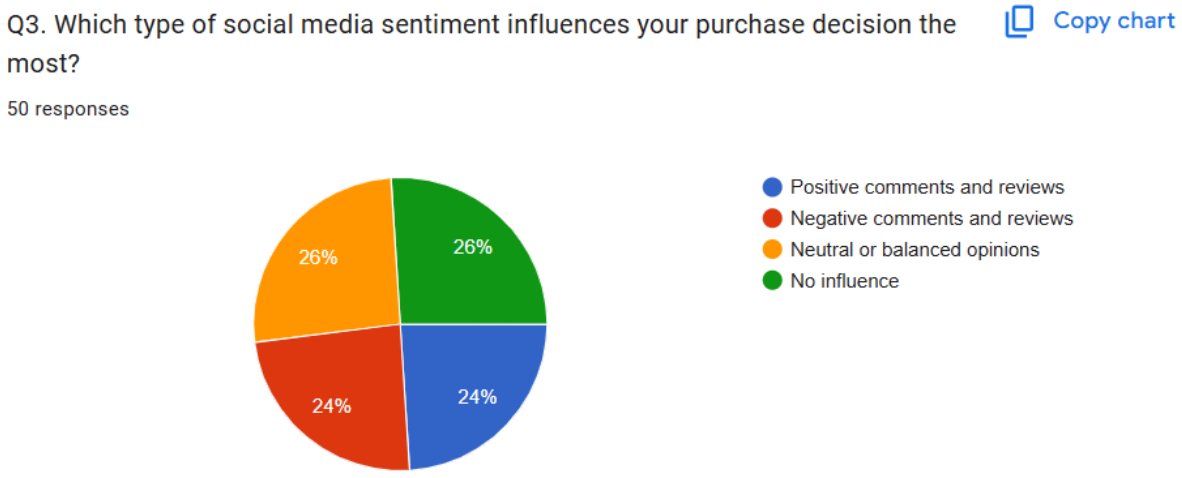


Figure: Influence of Different Types of Social Media Sentiment

Source: (self-created)

The findings revealed that the responses of the consumers are somewhat even in terms of the effects of different types of sentiment expressed in social media. 24% are impacted by positive comments and reviews, and the same number are impacted by negative comments. 26% of the participants were neutral in their opinions and answers, not influenced by either. The results suggest that consumers do not only react to positive or negative information, but also to both positive and negative information. Businesses should develop a tone that is balanced, credible and authentic in their communication.

4.

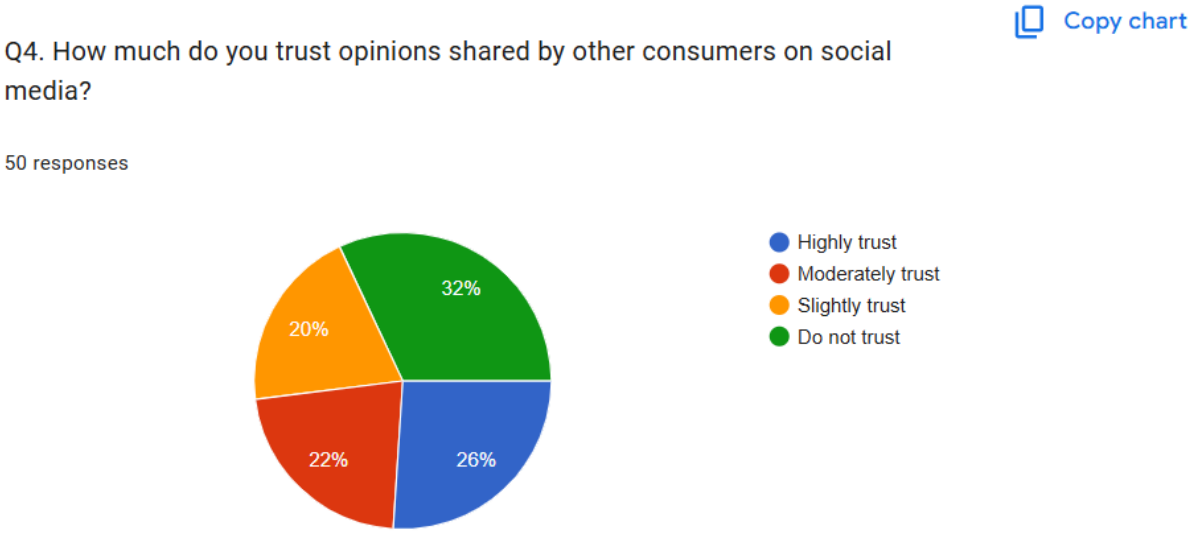


Figure: Consumer Trust in Social Media Opinions

Source: (self-created)

The findings show differing degrees of "trust" for opinions being shared through social media amongst consumers. 26% reported having a high level of trust in such opinions, while 32% reported that they didn't trust such opinions. 22% of the responses were moderate, and 20% were slight. The results point to the fact that social media plays a significant role in purchasing behaviour, but the issue of the credibility and authenticity of online information is widespread. To foster customer trust and make social media marketing efforts more effective, businesses should strive to boost transparency by making it easy for customers to leave reviews that can be verified.

5.

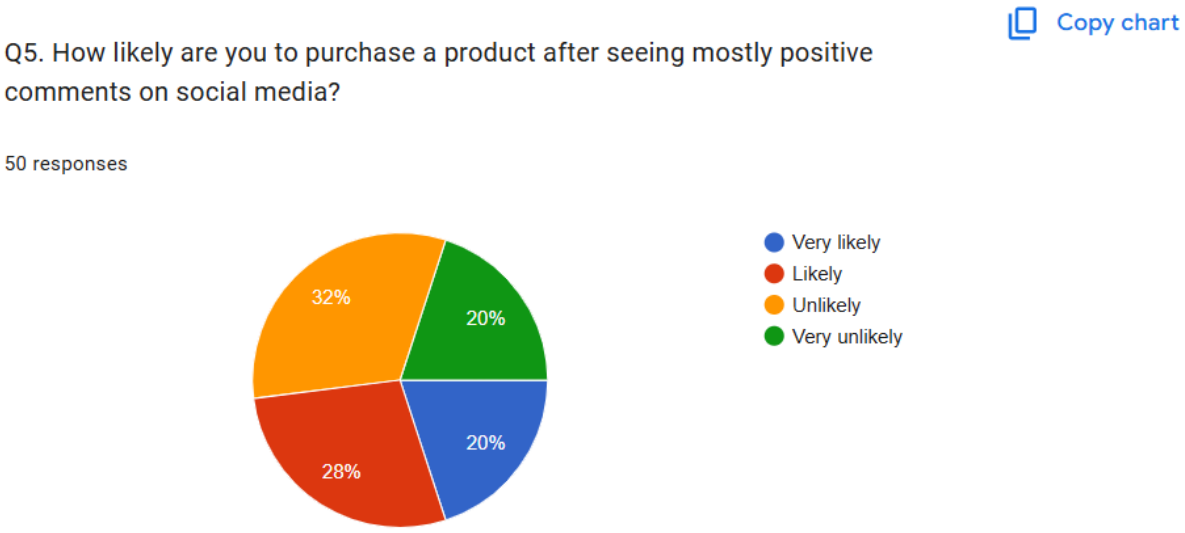


Figure: Influence of Positive Comments on Purchase Intentions

Source: (self-created)

The survey outcomes make it clear that the positive comments received on social media have a moderate impact on consumers' buying intentions. 28% of respondents indicated they were likely to purchase a product after reading positive comments, and 20% were very likely. But 20% said they are very unlikely, and 32% said they are unlikely to buy even with positive feedback. This research revealed that the positive attitude on social media alone is not enough to sway a lot of consumers. Some other elements that can affect the decision to buy the product include the quality of the product, price, brand reputation and experience.

6.

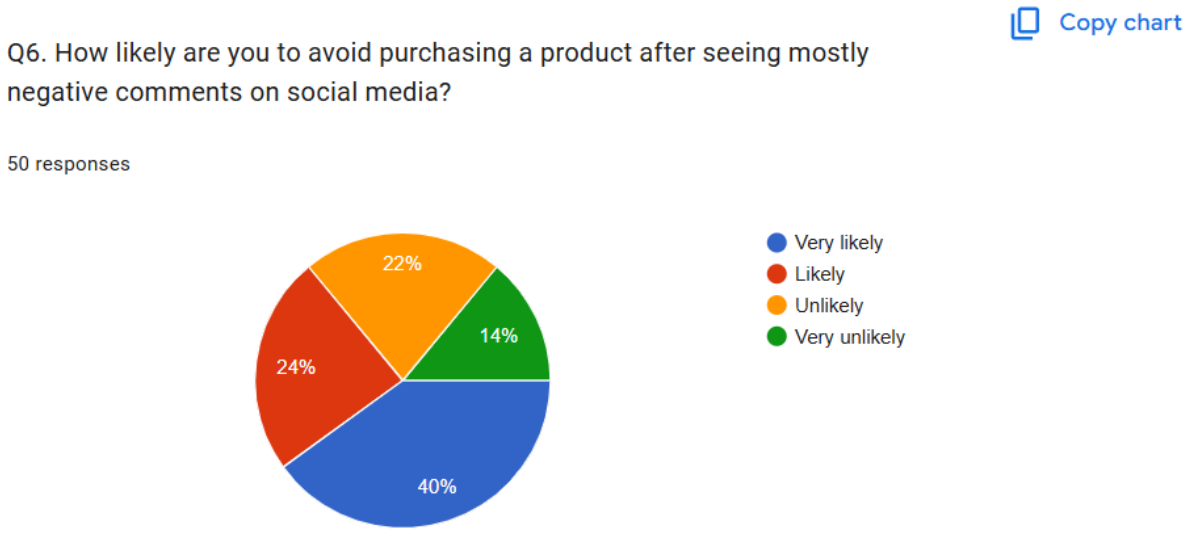


Figure: Influence of Negative Comments on Purchase Avoidance

Source: (self-created)

The study findings reveal that indeed the negative comments on social media platforms have a significant impact on consumers' buying intention. Of those respondents who indicated they were very likely to avoid buying a product after seeing primarily negative comments, 40% did so, with 24% saying they were likely to avoid it. In comparison, 22% were unlikely, and only 14% were very unlikely to change their purchasing decisions. Companies must take action quickly to address consumers' complaints, resolve their service-related issues more effectively and proactively control their online reputation to minimise potential damage to consumers' buying intention.

7.

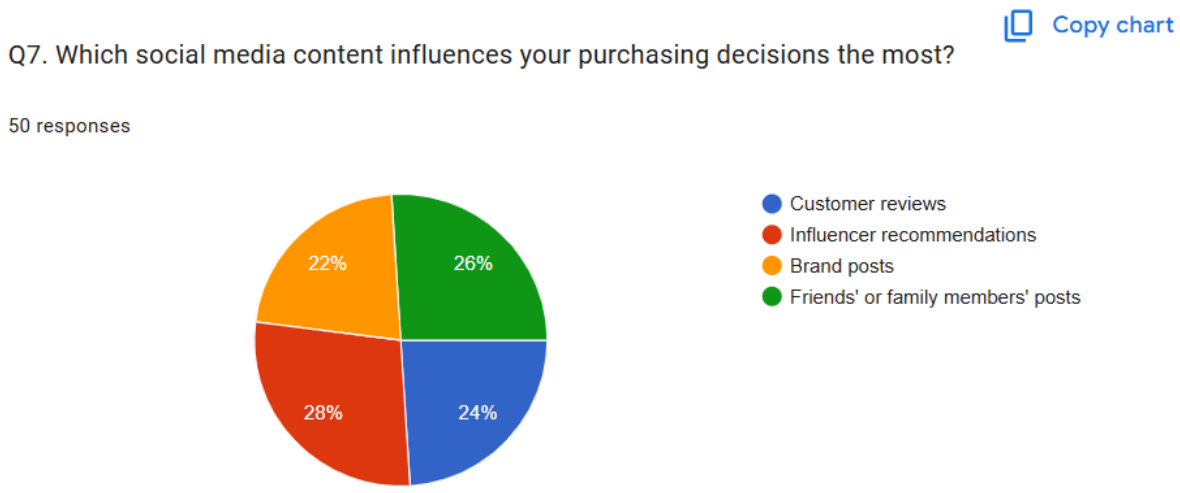


Figure: Most Influential Social Media Information Source

Source: (self-created)

Video articles are the most impactful source of social media content with 28% of the responses, after influencer recommendations. Customer reviews are the 2nd most influential (24%) after friends and family members' posts. Friends' and family members' posts are the next highest influence groups at 26% respectively, followed by official brand posts with the lowest influence at 22%. The findings show that people would rather trust a suggestion by another consumer who they think is sincere and speaks to them rather than a business. Organisations should spend more on collaborating with reputable influencers, encourage happy customers and ensure that user-generated content has a positive impact.

8.

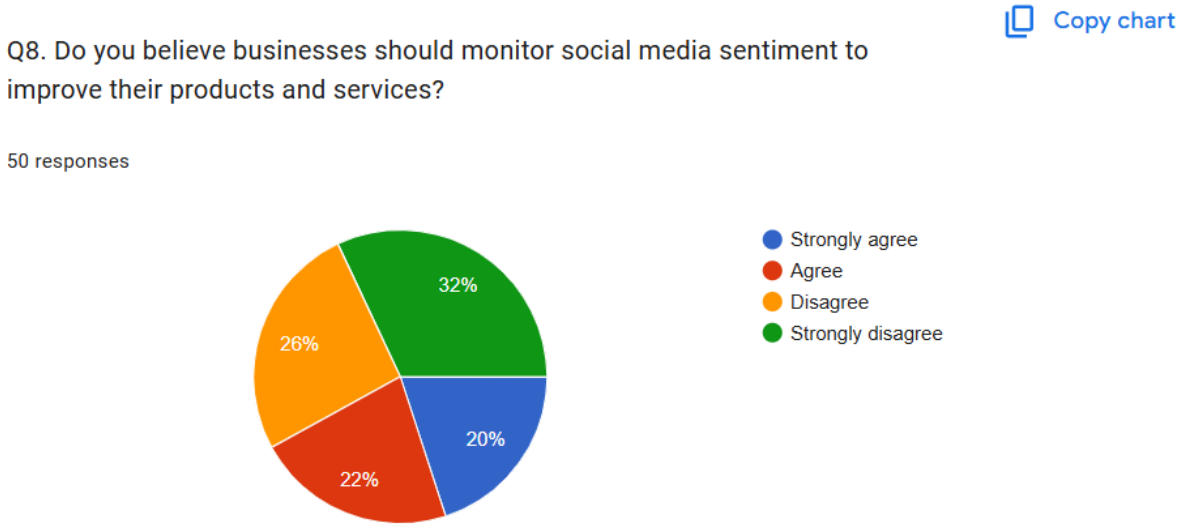


Figure: Consumer Opinions on Business Monitoring of Social Media Sentiment

Source: (self-created)

The results show mixed attitudes towards businesses being active on social media sentiment monitoring. 58% of respondents strongly disagreed or disagreed with this practice, 22% agreed, and 20% strongly agreed. The results showed that there are still a lot of consumers who are concerned about privacy and data usage, as well as the ethics of the organisations monitoring the online conversations. Businesses need to ensure that they are clear about what they do with consumer data, how they are collected, how they are analysed and how they are used, and explain that sentiment analytics is used to enhance their products, services and customer experience.

9.

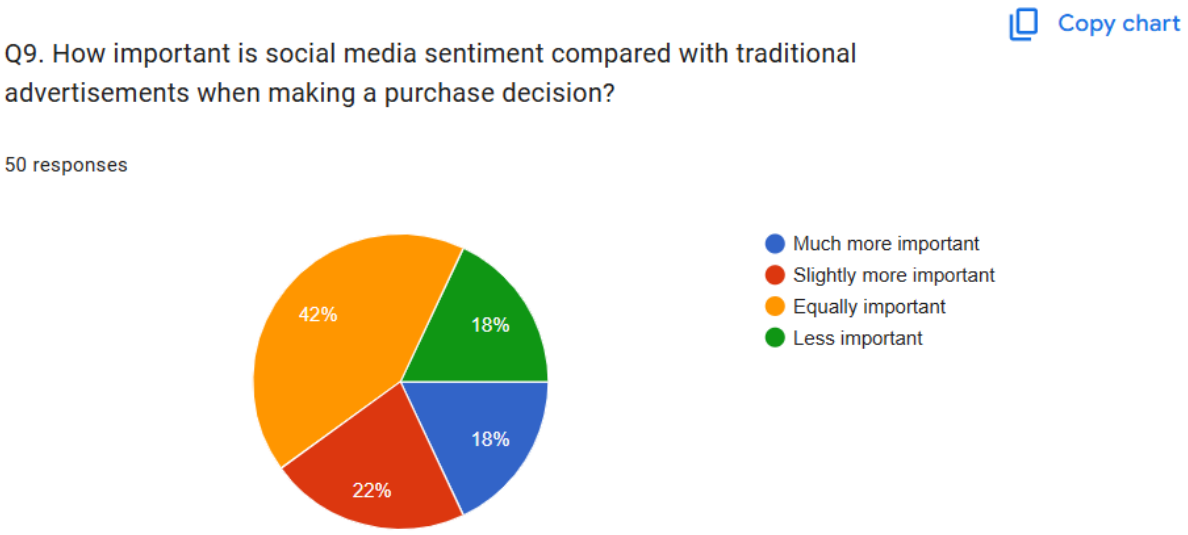


Figure: Importance of Social Media Sentiment Compared with Traditional Advertising

Source: (self-created)

According to the survey results, social media sentiment plays as much of a role in people's purchasing decisions as traditional advertising. 42% see both as being equally important, 22% see social media sentiment as slightly more important, and 18% believe it to be much more important. Another 18% say that it's not as important as traditional advertising at all. The results indicate that consumers are turning to a hybrid approach to purchasing, using a mix of digital interactions and traditional promotional activities. Hence, social media engagement should be a part of the marketing mix of organisations to build brand awareness, trust and marketing effectiveness.

10.

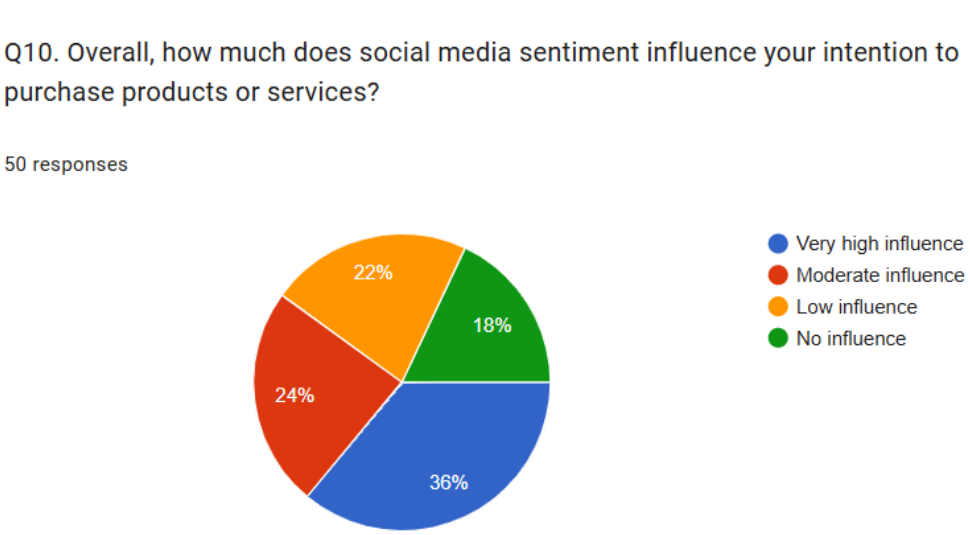


Figure: Overall Influence of Social Media Sentiment on Purchase Intentions

Source: (self-created)

Among the respondents who answered, 36% indicated social media sentiment has a very strong influence on their purchasing decisions, while 24% indicated it has a moderate influence. Only 22% indicated that social media sentiment had low influence on their purchasing decisions, and 18% indicated that social media sentiment did not influence their purchasing decisions at all. These findings indicate that a considerable number of consumers are swayed by what they read online before making a product or service purchase, and they are also influenced by opinions shared online about products and services.

4.2 Analysis

This study shows that social media sentiment analysis is one of the key factors that influence consumers' buying decisions, although this influence depends on the sentiment type, the credibility of the information and the source of the Internet content. Survey responses indicate that consumers are actively on social media before buying and frequently leverage the discussions, recommendations and reviews on various social media platforms. This indicates that social media is playing an important role in the customer decision-making process, and social media sentiment analysis can help businesses understand consumer sentiment.

The results highlight the power of TikTok and Instagram when it comes to influencing purchase decisions. These sites feature interesting graphics, brief videos, bloggers and customer-created video content to promote products and real-life experiences. Facebook was the lowest rated option, showing consumers are moving away from the traditional social networking site in favour of more interactive, visual options. The shift highlights the importance of platform selection in the process of businesses creating digital marketing strategies. Platforms that facilitate greater consumer engagement and sharing of information are important for organisations aiming to level up customer engagement.

One other key discovery is that more than half of respondents check out social media reviews and opinions before buying. Most respondents indicated they do read reviews before purchasing a product, a few indicated they never do. This is a testament to the fact that social media is already a potent source of information during the purchasing process. As they believe that the views of fellow consumers are more genuine than those of formal advertising, consumer experiences are increasingly important to them. Hence, businesses must monitor the conversations that take place online and be active in finding positive feedback from customers that aids in fostering trust in the brand.

The research also confirms that positive and negative social media opinions have an effect on purchasing behaviour, but not in the same way. As the results show, positive comments will help consumers make a purchasing decision, but it doesn't mean they will purchase the product. Many of the respondents also point out that the positive reviews don't make a difference for them and that other factors such as product quality, price, brand and previous user experiences are equally

important in their decision-making. This finding has implications for brands and companies beyond simply generating good online sentiment, it is about making sure their products and services deliver on their promise every time.

But it appears that negative sentiment has an even greater effect on consumer behaviour than positive sentiment. When many customers see mostly negative reviews on social media, they do not consider purchasing the product, many said. This is a consumer asymmetric response – negative experiences are powerful and stand out more than positive experiences and have a greater impact on behaviour. The finding proves how important it is to have positive corporate reputation management. Companies have to respond to complaints in a timely fashion, solve customer problems as quickly as possible, and keep negative online conversations from starting to affect customer confidence and customer buying decisions, if this is going to happen.

The results also highlight the issue of a lack of trust in social media environments. Most respondents said they felt that online opinions influenced their purchasing decisions, but they don't trust social media content information completely. A moderate or slight level of trust was reported by some regarding opinions they read online, and a smaller proportion of people reported a high level of trust in opinions they read online. The results indicate that problems like fake reviews and misleading promotional material/sponsored suggestions are still important concerns for consumers' trust. Hence, in the long run, businesses should work towards transparency by providing genuine customer reviews, truthful information about products, and honest communication to foster trust with customers.

The responses reveal that the source of information is influential in the buying intention. Customer reviews and posts from friends and family were next most influential, followed by posts from influencers and the official brand posts the least. As such, consumers appear to be more willing to believe those they feel are independent or that relate to them, as opposed to advertising from organisations. The discovery is further proof of the significance of influencer marketing and user-generated content in digital marketing. Organisations need to collaborate with trusted influencers and attempt to embed their customers in the organisation, offering a meaningful experience for the customers to gain confidence in the organisation.

Interestingly, the findings reveal a mixed attitude towards sentiment monitoring in businesses on social media. More than half of respondents believe that personal information privacy and concerns about data misuse and/or ethical considerations prevent organisations from analysing consumer discussion. A few participants knew the significance of sentiment analytics in improving products and services, but many of them doubted the actions that the company was taking on monitoring. The results suggest that organisations need to communicate the benefits of sentiment analysis to consumers and follow ethical guidelines and data protection laws.

Respondents overall do not see sentiment on social media and traditional ads as competing outlets of information, but complementary. For the majority, social media sentiment was as influential as the product itself when buying, while some people found it to be a little more or much more influential. This is a testament to the fact that IMC is still relevant and combines the credibility of user-generated content with the reach of traditional advertising. Businesses must have several communication channels to ensure the same message is delivered and to boost consumer engagement.

In general, the results have fulfilled the objectives of the research and confirmed that social media sentiment analytics has a significant impact on consumer purchase intentions. Consumers are actively reading online opinions before purchasing, and negative sentiment has a more significant behavioural effect than positive sentiment. Some other factors affecting buying habits are trust in the brand, authenticity, influencers' recommendations, and honesty in businesses.

4.3 Discussion

4.3.1 Consumer Dependence on Social Media Information During Purchase Decision-Making

Growing Reliance on Social Media Platforms

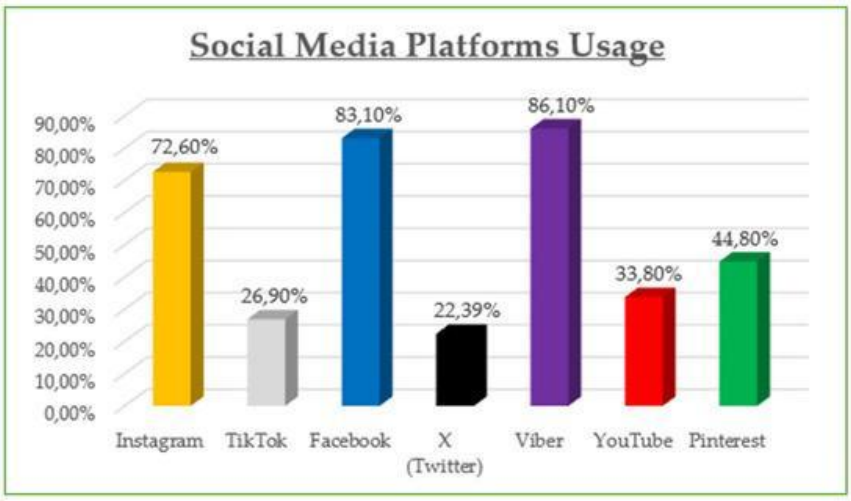


Figure: Growing Reliance on Social Media Platforms During Purchase Decision-Making

Source: (Migkos et al., 2025)

Results show that consumers are becoming more and more convinced that social media is a source for purchase. The outcomes from the results indicate that the TikTok and Instagram platforms have the greatest effect on consumer preferences, implying that content that is visually appealing and interactive has a greater influence on consumer preferences than other social networking platforms. These platforms are becoming more and more popular, that shows consumers are interested in information or a product demonstration and user experience before purchasing a product (Antczak, 2024). This information validates the current research that revealed social media's role as a source of information about products and demonstrates the rise of the adoption of content-rich social media platforms that provide real-product experiences.

Consumer Engagement with Online Reviews and Opinions

According to the survey, the majority of respondents are reading reviews, comments and opinions regularly prior to purchasing a product/service. Many of the participants reported that

they always, often, or sometimes get consumer information and feedback from the Internet, indicating a very high reliance on Internet consumer information and feedback. The results not only reinforce the fact that opinions are no longer just an optional source of information on the Internet, but it also shows that opinions have become part of the product evaluation before consumers purchase the products on the Internet (Cheung et al., 2022). As it turns out, people do not just want to read what they want to read – they want to read what others have to say as well, to defuse the uncertainty and increase their confidence when purchasing a certain type of product.

Integration of Social Media Information with Other Marketing Sources

The results indicate that social media sentiment is important but that consumers are not exclusively relying on online information to make buying decisions. A lot of respondents felt that while social media is not an alternative to traditional advertising media, its sentiment is as important. Before they make the purchase, consumers have information from advertisements, brand communication, online reviews, and personal recommendations (Maulid et al., 2022). Based on this, the outcome of this research adds to the body of knowledge by demonstrating that social media is an additional information source that can be used as part of a broader decision-making process.

Implications for Consumer Purchase Decision-Making

The results show that consumers' reliance on information from social media is not limited to the "passive" consumption of information online, but also involves a process of evaluation before the purchasing decision. Consumers appear to read the information they have on different sites and consider several opinions and sources before deciding on a purchase. This behaviour is representative of the influence of continuous engagement with digital information on purchase decisions, and not of the effect of specific marketing messages (Lariba, 2024). The results emphasize a presence on social media platforms, the importance of sincere social networking and the need to provide accurate information on products.

4.3.2 Differential Influence of Positive and Negative Online Sentiment on Purchase Intentions

Consumer Responses to Positive Online Sentiment

It is observed from the results that positive sentiment on social media can positively influence consumers' buying actions, but not in all aspects. Some were likely to purchase products because of positive reviews or comments, but it was not clear, and many were not likely to purchase products based on positive feedback. This implies that buyers take in positive information but carefully consider this information rather than take it on faith. The results suggest that positive online conversations boost awareness and confidence, but also appear to be taken on board in conjunction with other considerations like product quality, price, experience, and brand reputation (Zhang et al., 2022). Positive sentiment then helps us to make the purchase decision rather than being the purchase decision.

Stronger Behavioural Impact of Negative Online Sentiment

The results of the survey show that negative sentiment online has a much greater impact on consumer behaviour than positive sentiment. A lot of the respondents stated that they would not purchase a product if they noticed mostly negative reviews or comments. The result shows that negative information is given a higher value. It makes it more relevant for consumers because it points out the risks involved in buying the product. People's negative opinions seem to be more noteworthy and to elicit more emotional reactions than positive ones, and so are more influential when they are evaluating a product (Zhou, 2022). Consequently, if a business does not take action promptly when its customers are not satisfied, the business may lose a lot of trust in that business and decrease their purchases.

Balanced Evaluation of Positive, Negative, and Neutral Information

The findings also suggest that negative or positive feedback from online reviews is not necessarily affecting consumers. The positive, negative, neutral and no sentiment were fairly balanced, showing that there is a balance of consideration when people make purchases. It does not appear as if consumers merely take one review and one comment and are satisfied with it. This indicates that there are consumers who are becoming aware and critical of digital

information (Adi et al., 2024). The results suggest a more balanced discussion, and a real customer experience is more useful than having too many promotional messages, as they give customers more information to inform their buying decisions.

Marketing Implications of Sentiment Differences

The opposing positive and negative sentiment makes for some significant marketing implications. But negative sentiment can be more effective at impacting purchase intent, meaning it is likely that reputation management and the recovery of customer service will be two of the key components of an organisation's strategy for reducing negative online conversations. In the interim, companies need to continue building positive perceptions by encouraging customers to openly comment on their experiences, thereby improving their satisfaction. But producing good feedback is not a sufficient condition if the expectations are not met (Maulid et al., 2022). It is possible to say that dealing with the positive and negative sentiment on the Internet can help organisations to increase consumer confidence, improve their reputation and achieve better long-term purchasing results.

4.3.3 Trust, Credibility, and Consumer Evaluation of Social Media Content

Consumer Trust in Social Media Information

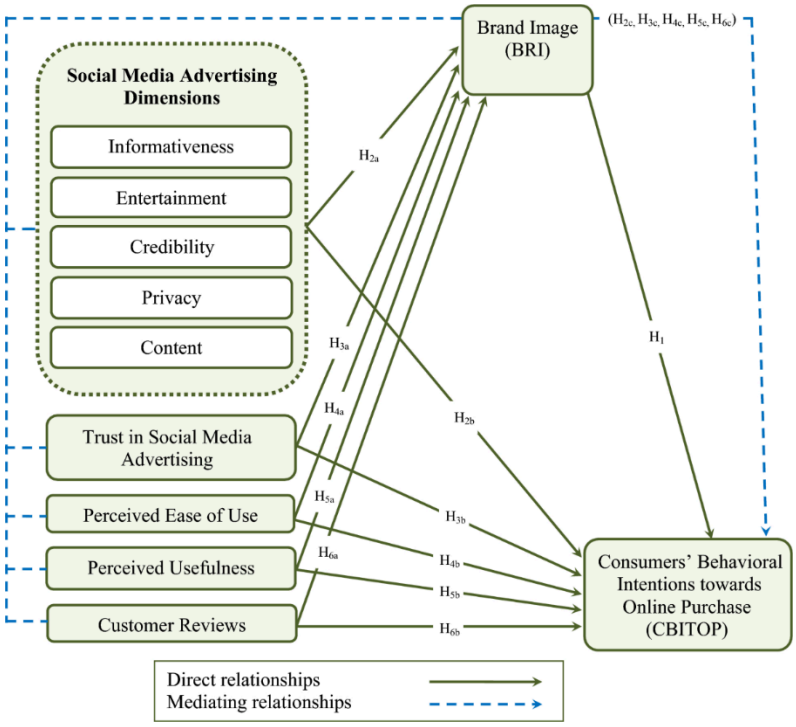


Figure: Consumer Trust in Social Media Information

Source: (Chowdhury and Ahmed, 2026)

The findings indicate that despite consumers' use of social media in the process of buying, trust in social media information is still divided. The majority of respondents said they do not trust opinions presented on social media, with smaller numbers of respondents saying they trust it a great deal, somewhat, or a little. This highlights that consumers believe that information online can be useful but are dubious about its veracity. The problem with fake reviews, sponsored content, bad recommendations, and manipulated ratings seems to affect consumers' assessment of information before a purchase (Isti'anah et al., 2022). Trust is an important factor in the consumer behaviour equation when trying to leverage social or news media sentiment.

Evaluation of Content Credibility Before Purchasing

The results also illustrate that consumers are not passive, but instead carefully consider what they see on social media and are not persuaded by things they read online unless they trust the source. Reads reviews and recommendations, discuss frequently and compare information from various sources before making a purchase. This behaviour is a reflection of a growing knowledgeable

and critical consumer who assesses the information that they have access to. For recommendations, content from trusted sources, verified customer experiences, and real conversations will likely be listened to more (Coutinho et al., 2023). Results suggest that credibility has to be built, not in terms of the amount of information on the Internet, but through transparency, consistency, and truthfulness to the customer.

Business Implications for Building Consumer Confidence

The findings also reveal that a few of the respondents are worried about organisations gaining access to social media conversations, suggesting that they are unaware of the importance of data privacy and ethics. Sentiment analytics can provide businesses with a more in-depth understanding of their customers, but consumers want businesses to do so responsibly and transparently. It is important for organisations to clearly explain how the information about consumers is captured, analysed and utilised to enhance products and services (Adi et al., 2024). Consumers tend to be more trusting of trusted reviews, and responding to criticism in an honest fashion and communicating openly may also help to build trust and enhance the credibility of online information.

4.3.4 Importance of Information Sources in Shaping Consumer Purchase Intentions

Influence of Different Social Media Platforms

The results reveal that the type of social media platform can have a significant impact on consumers' purchase intentions. It has been revealed that TikTok and Instagram are the most effective platforms, indicating that consumers are seeking information with visual appeal when deciding on products and services. They provide a chance to see demonstrations, customer experiences, and interactive content that gives them the information they need to make informed decisions on purchases (Thuy et al., 2024). Combining the results from the study, businesses should select social media platforms and be capable of optimising audience engagement and delivery of marketing to the platforms where the audience visits the most when assessing products.

Influence of Peer and Influencer Recommendations

The data shows that recommendations from influencers, friends, family and other consumers are important for consumers. The information source with the highest rate was recommendations from influencers, followed by recommendations from friends and family and customer reviews. The official brand posts were the least influential on purchasing. The findings here show that independent recommendations are more authentic and believable than those of organisations that are being promoted (Rajeev, 2024). Businesses cannot afford to wait for their customers to share their real experiences, and they must collaborate with trusted influencers that embody values that resonate with the brand to establish trust and purchase intent.

Consumer Comparison of Multiple Information Sources

Consumers seldom rely on one information source before buying. Instead, they study the feedback, suggestions, social media posts, ads and opinions of individuals, and then decide. As far as social media sentiment, respondents stated that it's as important as traditional advertising, meaning that there are multiple information sources behind buying decisions. This is a well-informed, vigilant buyer who would not take a product or service until they have had a positive experience from several sources (Coutinho et al., 2023). Organisations should then use the same style of message throughout all communication to make the message more credible and minimise any consumer's uncertainty.

Strategic Value of Credible Information Sources

The findings clearly demonstrate the importance of the trustworthiness of information sources when it comes to consumers' purchasing decisions. With most websites, the channels that seem to have the greatest impact on consumers' willingness to act are those from trusted people and authentic customer reviews, rather than direct promotional channels. This emphasises the importance of developing a customer-centric communication strategy for authentic communication and engagement. Organisations should focus on building business relations that emphasise establishing long-term relations with customers through user-generated content and verified reviews, and taking an active role in social media (Banerjee et al., 2025). The improvement of quality and reliability of information sources can contribute to consumer trust, increase consumer confidence in buying and make the sentiment analysis of social media even more useful for making marketing decisions.

4.3.5 Implications of Social Media Sentiment Analytics for Consumer-Centred Marketing Practices

Strengthening Consumer Understanding Through Sentiment Analytics

The results prove that sentiment analysis on social media can be used by organisations to gain insights into consumers' attitudes, preferences and buying intentions. Consumers contribute and express opinions through reviews, comments, ratings and discussions, and this constitutes an ongoing source of behavioural information. The findings suggest that by examining these interactions, businesses can gain deeper insights into their customers' expectations than through conventional market research methods. Consumer-centred marketing is improved by sentiment analytics as it helps organisations to capture new concerns, acknowledge good experiences and act on customer preferences quickly enough (Margarita et al., 2023). This helps in the development of products and services that meet consumer expectations and market needs.

Improving Customer Engagement Through Authentic Communication

Results indicate that the importance of communicating in a way that is perceived as authentic is key to enhancing consumer engagement. Authenticity is important in driving purchasing behaviour, as shown by the fact that participants valued the recommendations from influencers above official brand communications and the feedback they received from customers more than the communications themselves. Consumer-centred marketing should then strive to facilitate authentic communication between business and consumer, not just through promotion (Al Hamli and Sobaih, 2023). The practices show that companies care about customer feedback, that reinforces customers' trust in products and brands while enhancing customer relationships.

Supporting Reputation Management and Service Improvement

The finding shows a higher impact of negative sentiment, that is very important to take note of and will show why proactive reputation management is so important. When negative reviews are posted online about a product, consumer response is swift, and they are less likely to buy it, the speed of response to complaints and service failures is crucial (Banerjee et al., 2025). Sentiment analysis allows companies to detect customers' discontent at an early stage and take action to correct it before the news goes around further. Customer feedback can also be used to pinpoint

issues that need to be addressed, to adjust the quality of the services provided, and to enhance the performance of products (Deora et al., 2025). Sentiment analytics is a powerful tool for consumer-centred marketing, allowing businesses to leverage customer feedback for strategic decision-making and ultimately enhance their brand reputation and customer satisfaction.

Promoting Trust Through Ethical Data Practices

The results show that a lot of consumers continue to be worried about the authenticity of information on the web and how organisations monitor social media conversations. These concerns highlight the importance of consumer-centred marketing that is underpinned by responsible and ethical data management. Organisations should be transparent about the way that consumer information is gathered, analysed and utilised and ensure that they are compliant with relevant privacy laws and standards (Rajeev, 2024). Clear communication, authentic customer reviews and honest interactions lead to higher consumer trust. Sentiment Analytics can improve the credibility of an organisation and boost customer acceptance of businesses on digital channels when used ethically.

Developing More Effective Consumer-Focused Marketing Strategies

The results highlight the potential of social media sentiment analysis for the creation of more effective marketing strategies focused on consumers. By leveraging information gained from online conversations, businesses can tailor their communication more effectively, enhance customer experiences, optimise promotional strategies, and cultivate better relationships with their target audience. The study suggests that there are various sources of information that affect the consumer's purchase decision, that further emphasises the need for constant monitoring of the consumer's sentiments, especially in these days of the 21st century (Banerjee et al., 2025). Sentiment analytics should be considered not just as a technology, but as a strategic asset that can drive trust, satisfaction, loyalty, and sustainable business growth by fostering customer-centric marketing strategies.

4.3.6 Strategic Recommendations for Enhancing Consumer Engagement Through Sentiment Analytics

Strengthening Real-Time Consumer Listening and Response

The information revealed that consumers are actively using social media information before their buying decisions, which means that there is a need to monitor social media discussions continuously. Sentiment analytics should be real-time, as it helps organisations discover customers' thoughts, emerging issues, and shifting preferences as they happen. Quick feedback on customer requests and complaints, as well as feedback, shows that businesses value consumer feedback and want to enhance the experience of their customers (Srivastava et al., 2024). Early engagement can also help to minimise the potential damage to brands' reputations and stop the negative discussion from proliferating. Organisations can enhance consumer trust and build better relationships with their target audiences by embracing proactive social listening strategies.

Encouraging Authentic User-Generated Content and Influencer Collaboration



Figure: Encouraging Authentic User-Generated Content

Source: (Hernandez, 2025)

The results show that consumers trust more in the recommendations of influencers, customer reviews, and personal experiences than in official brand communication. Companies should promote content from happy clients and customers on social media platforms that are genuine

and authentic reviews, testimonials, and product experiences. Working with trusted influencers who share the organisation's values can also help to build consumer trust and raise awareness (Singh et al., 2023). Instead of solely promoting, organisations should look to provide opportunities for real customers to engage and be a part of the community. User-generated content is more credible, engages consumers more, and can positively affect consumer purchase decisions through trusted social recommendations.

Building Trust Through Transparency and Ethical Practices

The results show that there is still a lack of consumers' trust in the credibility of online information and social media monitoring. Organisations should ensure that they communicate and manage data transparently. It is essential for businesses to have a clear policy for collecting and utilising customer feedback and to adhere to privacy laws and regulations. Addressing customer concerns with transparency, promoting genuine reviews and steering clear of promotional content can boost organisational credibility (Deora et al., 2025). Clear and honest handling of processes can foster consumer confidence, support sustained engagement and enable customers to engage more openly in online product and/or service discussions.

Integrating Sentiment Analytics into Marketing Decision-Making

The study shows that sentiment analytics can be used to gain useful insights that help understand consumer attitude and behaviour, and can be beneficial for strategic marketing decisions. Sentiment analysis should be incorporated into the planning process of campaigns, product development, and enhancing customer service and reputation management in organisations. Consumers' feedback can be analysed regularly to help businesses gauge market trends, assess campaign effectiveness, and tweak marketing strategies based on customer preferences (Lariba, 2024). By integrating sentiment analysis with traditional marketing strategies, organisations can create more personalised and relevant customer experiences. Businesses can leverage sentiment analytics to reinforce customer engagement, boost customer satisfaction, foster brand loyalty, and ensure long-term competitive advantage in the increasingly digital marketplace by embedding sentiment analytics into decision-making processes.

CONCLUSION

This study aimed to explore the effects of social media sentiment analysis on consumers' purchasing intentions by studying how consumer opinions, reviews, and discussions on social media affect consumers' decision-making process. As social media continues to be popular, it has become an integral part of consumers' information search processes, as well as their evaluation of products and brand interaction. Organisations have been increasing their use of digital data to better understand customer behaviour, and sentiment analytics is proving to be an important instrument to understand customer sentiment and guide marketing decisions. Overall, the study was successful in exploring the correlation between social media sentiment and buying intentions as well as understanding the influence of positive and negative sentiment and the role of sentiment analysis in understanding consumer behaviour and making tangible recommendations for organisations to improve consumer engagement.

The literature review indicated that social media has evolved from a means of communication to a powerful marketing medium where user-generated content, eWOM, the word of influencers, and consumer interactions have a real influence on consumers' perceptions. Previous studies highlighted the growing importance of artificial intelligence (AI), machine learning and natural language processing (NLP) technologies in sentiment analysis for Internet platforms and the analysis of large volumes of digital information. Previous research also showed the impact that trust, credibility, authenticity and social proof have on consumer reactions to online information. A few challenges were identified during the research and literature reading on the ability of the consumer to integrate positive, negative and neutral sentiment in purchasing decisions, and how sentiment analytics is useful to businesses to implement it in consumer-centred marketing. The purpose of this study was to address these gaps by examining the active social media users' responses in an empirical manner.

The researcher used a quantitative method with the use of a structured questionnaire, distributed to the 50 respondents who are active users of social media using a convenience sampling strategy. The method enabled capturing consistent numerical data that showed the respondents' attitude towards social media sentiment analytics and its effect on purchasing attitude.

Descriptive analysis with frequencies and percentages, charts and graphical presentations was used to reveal the attitudes of the consumers. The results of the study are not generalizable because the sample size and non-probability sampling technique restricted the generalizability of the results, but it still provided valuable evidence and information about consumer behaviour in the current digital environment.

The results confirmed that social media is considered one of the significant information sources in the entire buying process. Leveraging electronic word-of-mouth (eWoM) is a key source of information for consumers when buying, with these respondents often reading reviews, comments, ratings and discussions before they buy. TikTok and Instagram were among those platforms that were the most influential, with consumers being drawn to content that is intriguing and interactive. Relying on traditional advertising is no longer the most important factor for consumers, and they take information from various digital platforms before buying a product. The results underline the increasing relevance of a strong and active profile on the relevant social media channels.

The study also validated the differential impact of positive vs. negative sentiments online on purchasing behaviour. If they get positive reviews and recommendations, they would be more confident of the product and become more aware of it, that might lead to increased sales. Consumers' buying decisions are not only driven by sentiment, but also by product quality, price, previous experience and brand reputation. Negative sentiment on the contrary, on the other hand, has a stronger impact by inducing consumers to refrain from purchasing products associated with negative online discussions. This finding underscores the importance of having a well-managed reputation, timely complaints and good customer service to counteract the effects of negative online sentiment.

The results indicated that trust and credibility had a significant impact on the online reactions of the respondents to the messages presented in social media. Many of the respondents were frequently searching online for information, but at the same time, they were also concerned about receiving reviews, sponsored content, and false recommendations. The assessment of the different information sources precedes the consumers' purchasing decision, so that the consumers' perceptions of information credibility are also part of the purchasing decision. Other

results revealed that brand communications didn't prove to be as persuasive as personal recommendations, customer reviews and influencer recommendations. The participants were concerned about the role of social media monitoring within organisations, stressing the need for transparency, ethical practices with regard to data collected, and responsible use of sentiment analysis to preserve consumer trust.

The research offers several implications on the practical side for organisations in competitive digital markets. Sentiment analytics should be incorporated into businesses' marketing decision-making processes to get a better understanding of customers, keep track of changes in consumer sentiment, and identify areas for improvement in services. By leveraging continuous social listening, organisations can address customer inquiries swiftly, reduce reputational risks, and build customer relationships. Encouraging genuine user-generated content, building relationships with trusted influencers, including genuine customer endorsements, and promoting honest communication can help further strengthen consumer trust and purchase intentions. Apart from being involved in social media marketing, enterprises should combine it with other marketing campaigns to formulate a unified brand message that hits multiple channels.

There are a number of limitations in the study. This is due to the convenience sampling and the small number of respondents (50), that limits generalisability to the larger population. The cross-sectional design does not record shifts in behaviour caused by changing market conditions or technologies, as it only records consumer opinions at one time. The use of self-reported responses could also potentially cause response bias as respondents may not always accurately describe their purchasing behaviour. In future studies, larger and more diverse samples, longitudinal designs and industry and geographical comparisons should be applied. Other new technologies, such as new Artificial Intelligence and predictive sentiment analysis, could also help to gain a better understanding of future consumer behaviour.

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APPENDIX

Questionnaire

Q1. Which social media platform most influences your product purchasing decisions?

Facebook

Instagram

TikTok

X (Twitter)

Q2. How often do you read social media reviews, comments, or opinions before purchasing a product?

Always

Often

Sometimes

Never

Q3. Which type of social media sentiment influences your purchase decision the most?

Positive comments and reviews

Negative comments and reviews

Neutral or balanced opinions

No influence

Q4. How much do you trust opinions shared by other consumers on social media?

Highly trust

Moderately trust

Slightly trust

Do not trust

Q5. How likely are you to purchase a product after seeing mostly positive comments on social media?

Very likely

Likely

Unlikely

Very unlikely

Q6. How likely are you to avoid purchasing a product after seeing mostly negative comments on social media?

Very likely

Likely

Unlikely

Very unlikely

Q7. Which social media content influences your purchasing decisions the most?

Customer reviews

Influencer recommendations

Brand posts

Friends' or family members' posts

Q8. Do you believe businesses should monitor social media sentiment to improve their products and services?

Strongly agree

Agree

Disagree

Strongly disagree

Q9. How important is social media sentiment compared with traditional advertisements when making a purchase decision?

Much more important

Slightly more important

Equally important

Less important

Q10. Overall, how much does social media sentiment influence your intention to purchase products or services?

Very high influence

Moderate influence

Low influence

No influence